Specification of the controlled designation of origin "FRONSAC"

approved by the order of 10 December 2024 published in the JORF of 12 December 2024

CHAPTER I

I. – Name of the designation

Only wines meeting the specific provisions set out below may claim the controlled designation of origin "Fronsac", initially recognised by the decree of 4 March 1937.

II. – Geographical denominations and complementary terms

No specific provision.

III. – Colour and types of product

The controlled designation of origin "Fronsac" is reserved for still red wines.

IV. – Areas and zones in which the various operations are carried out

1° – Geographical area

The harvesting of the grapes, the vinification, the elaboration and the ageing of the wines are carried out within the territory of the following communes of the Gironde department, on the basis of the official geographic code dated 20 February 2024: Fronsac, La Rivière, Saillans, Saint-Aignan, Saint-Germain-de-la-Rivière, Saint-Michel-de-Fronsac and on part of the territory of the commune of Galgon for the parcels registered under cadastre BM 42, BM 67, BM 68, BN 24, BN 25, BN 26, BN 27, BN 28, BN 29, BN 30, BN 31, BN 32, BN 33, BN 81 and BN 87.

2° – Delimited parcel area

The wines come exclusively from vines situated within the delimited parcel production area as approved by the National Institute of Origin and Quality at the session of the competent national committee of 25 June 1987.

The National Institute of Origin and Quality lodges with the town halls of the communes referred to in 1° the graphic documents establishing the parcel boundaries of the production area thus approved.

3° – Immediate proximity area

The immediate proximity area, defined by derogation for the vinification, the elaboration and the ageing of the wines, is made up of the territory of the following communes of the Gironde department, on the basis of the official geographic code dated 20 February 2024: Libourne, Lugon-et-l'Ile-du-Carnay, Villegouge and part of the territory of the commune of Galgon with the exception of the parcels registered under cadastre BM 42, BM 67, BM 68, BN 24, BN 25, BN 26, BN 27, BN 28, BN 29, BN 30, BN 31, BN 32, BN 33, BN 81 and BN 87.

V. – Grape varieties

1° – Grape varieties

The wines come from the following varieties:

- main varieties: cabernet franc N, cabernet-sauvignon N, merlot N, cot N (or malbec);

- accessory varieties: carmenère N, petit verdot N.

2° – Proportion rules on the holding

- The proportion of the main varieties is greater than or equal to 80 % of the grape varieties.

- The proportion of each of the carmenère N or petit verdot N varieties is less than or equal to 10 % of the grape varieties.

The compliance of the grape varieties is assessed over all the parcels of the holding producing the wine of the appellation.

VI. – Management of the vineyard

1° – Training methods

a) – Planting density.
The vines present a minimum planting density of 5,000 plants per hectare. These vines may not present a spacing between rows greater than 2 metres nor a spacing between plants within the same row of less than 0.80 metre.

b) – Pruning rules.
Pruning is carried out at the latest by the spread-leaves stage (Lorenz stage 9) according to the following techniques: single Guyot or double Guyot pruning, or spur (cots or coursons) pruning in cordon or fan, or cane (astes or long-wood) pruning, with a maximum of 12 free eyes (buds) per plant. In all cases, the overlapping of the long woods (canes) is prohibited.

c) – Trellising rules and foliage height.
The height of the trellised foliage is at least equal to 0.6 times the spacing between rows, the height of trellised foliage being measured at its lower limit at 0.10 metre below the bending wire and at its upper limit at the topping height.

d) – Average maximum load per parcel.
- The average maximum load per parcel is fixed at 9,000 kilograms per hectare. This load corresponds to a maximum number of 14 bunches per plant. - Where irrigation is authorised in accordance with the provisions of Article D. 645-5 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, the average maximum load per parcel of the irrigated parcels is fixed at 6,500 kilograms per hectare.

e) – Threshold for missing vines.
The percentage of dead or missing vine plants, referred to in Article D. 645-4 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, is fixed at 20 %. Dead plants must be removed from the parcels; any storage of these dead plants on the parcels is prohibited.

f) – Cultivation condition of the vine.
The parcels are managed so as to ensure a good overall cultivation condition of the vine, in particular its sanitary condition and the upkeep of its soil. In particular, no parcel is left abandoned.

2° – Other cultivation practices

In order to preserve the characteristics of the physical and biological environment that constitutes a fundamental element of the terroir:

- The grassing of the headlands is compulsory;

- The vegetation is controlled either mechanically or by equipment ensuring a precise localisation of the treatment products. In this last case, the area chemically weeded may not be greater than 30 cm on each side of the vine row;

Every operator calculates and records its treatment frequency index (IFT).

- Any substantial modification of the morphology of the relief and of the natural pedological sequence of the parcels intended for the production of the controlled designation of origin is prohibited, with the exception of classic deep-ploughing works.

- The addition of exogenous soil onto parcels of the delimited parcel area is prohibited. Exogenous soil means soil that does not come from the delimited parcel area of the controlled designation of origin.

3° – Irrigation

Irrigation during the vine's growing period may be authorised, in accordance with the provisions of Article D. 645-5 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, only in the event of persistent drought and when this

disturbs the good physiological development of the vine and the good ripeness of the grape.

VII. – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes

1° – Harvest

The wines come from grapes harvested at proper ripeness and presenting a good sanitary condition.

2° – Ripeness of the grapes

a) – Sugar content of the grapes. Grapes with a sugar content of less than the following may not be considered to be at proper ripeness:

- 198 grams per litre of must for the merlot N variety;

- 180 grams per litre of must for the other varieties.

b) – Minimum natural alcoholic strength by volume. The wines present a minimum natural alcoholic strength by volume of 11 %.

VIII. – Yield. – Entry into production

1° – Yield

The yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 53 hectolitres per hectare.

2° – Limit yield

The limit yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 65 hectolitres per hectare.

3° – Entry into production of young vines

The benefit of the controlled designation of origin may be granted to wines coming from:

- parcels of young vines only from the 2nd year following that in the course of which planting was carried out in place before 31 July;

- parcels of young vines only from the 1st year following that in the course of which grafting in place was carried out before 31 July;

- parcels of vines that have been top-grafted, at the earliest in the 1st year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July and once the parcels no longer contain any varieties other than those permitted for the appellation. By way of derogation, in the year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July, the varieties permitted for the appellation may represent only 80 % of the grape varieties of each parcel concerned.

IX. – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage

1° – General provisions

The wines are vinified in accordance with local, fair and constant usages.

a) – Blending of the varieties. - The proportion of the main varieties is greater than or equal to 50 % in the blends.

b) – Malolactic fermentation. Every lot of wine marketed (in bulk or packaged) presents a malic acid content less than or equal to 0.30 gram per litre.

c) – Analytical standards.

- Every lot of wine marketed (in bulk or packaged) presents a content of fermentable sugars (glucose + fructose) less than or equal to 3 grams per litre;

- Every lot of wine marketed (in bulk) presents a volatile acidity content less than or equal to 13.26 milliequivalents per litre, i.e. 0.79 gram per litre expressed as acetic acid (0.65 gram per litre expressed as H2SO4);

- Every lot of wine marketed (in bulk) presents a total sulphur dioxide content less than or equal to 140 milligrams per litre.

e) – Oenological practices and physical treatments.

- Subtractive enrichment techniques (SET) are authorised within the limit of a concentration rate of 15 %.

- After enrichment, the wines do not exceed a total alcoholic strength by volume of 13.5 %.

f) – Prohibited equipment.

- The use of the foulobenne (self-emptying skip fitted with a so-called centrifugal paddle pump) is prohibited.

- The use of the continuous-type press fitted with an endless screw of a diameter less than 400 millimetres is prohibited.

g) – Vat capacity. Every operator has a vinification vat capacity at least equal to 1.5 times the average ten-year claimed production of the holding. The vinification capacity available at the time of harvest corresponds to the vinification containers.

h) – Overall condition of upkeep of the cellar and equipment. The cellar (floors and walls) and the vinification equipment present a good general condition of upkeep.

2° – Provisions by type of product

The wines undergo ageing at least until 1 June of the year following that of the harvest.

3° – Provisions relating to packaging

- For each packaged lot, the operator sends to the approved control body, accompanying the prior packaging declaration, an analysis of the lot to be packaged carried out before packaging, and keeps available for the approved control body the information appearing in the register of handling operations referred to in Article D. 645-18 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code;

- The analysis reports are kept for a period of 6 months from the date of packaging.

- For continuous or semi-continuous operators as defined in Chapter II, the analyses of the packaged lots are kept available for the approved control body in accordance with the provisions defined in the inspection plan.

4° – Provisions relating to storage

The operator demonstrates a suitable protected place for the storage of the packaged products. A suitable place for the storage of packaged products means any place sheltered from bad weather (wind, rain) and protected from any contamination.

5° – Provisions relating to the movement of products and to placing on the market for the consumer

Date of placing on the market for the consumer. At the end of the ageing period, the wines are placed on the market for the consumer from 30 June of the year following that of the harvest.

X. – Link with the geographical area

1° – Information on the geographical area

a) – Description of the natural factors contributing to the link

The geographical area of the controlled designation of origin “Fronsac” is situated on the right bank of the Dordogne, at the confluence with the Isle. This region is situated in the north-east of the department, separated from Libourne, to the east, by the valley of the Isle.

The climate is temperate oceanic with moderate temperature ranges favouring the cultivation of the vine, as for the whole of the Gironde on the edge of the Atlantic Ocean. Unpredictable, the oceanic climate may, in some years, translate into rainy autumn depressions or, on the contrary, into warm and very sunny late seasons. This variability is at the origin of the marked vintage effect.

The rather steep hillsides and the proximity of the two rivers, the Dordogne and the Isle, favour the protection of the vines against frosts and accumulations of cold air. The relief is rugged, marked by several rocky promontories called “tertres” (mounds). The highest is the Tertre de Fronsac, which culminates at 76 metres dominating the valley of the Isle and the Dordogne, and from which one can see, a few kilometres away, Pomerol and Saint-Emilion.

The parcels intended for the harvesting of the grape are part of a precisely delimited area which excludes the alluvial zones of the lower valleys of the Isle and the Dordogne to retain only the vines on hillsides. The vineyard is mainly established on the molassic slopes (molasse of the “Fronsadais”) represented by sands of greater or lesser coarseness, sometimes accompanied by sandstone, or by a sandy clay where brown calcareous soils have formed, and on the plateau on “Asteria” limestone where clay-limestone soils or clay-sandy soils have formed. The “Castillon” limestone forms a generally wooded corniche that crops out on the flank of the plateaux running along the Dordogne.

Thus the geographical area of the controlled designation of origin “Fronsac” extends over the territory of 6 communes of the Gironde department and a few parcels of the commune of Galgon.

The landscape is set among the wine-growing landscapes of the Libourne area, formed of hillsides covered with vineyards sometimes established on terraces and underlined by a corniche of wooded white limestone, overlooking the Dordogne and the Isle. The vineyards are punctuated by villages built of limestone with tiled roofs and by Romanesque churches, some of which were erected in the 11th and 12th centuries. Magnificent wine châteaux, witnesses of the historic dynamism of the controlled designation of origin, overlook the valley of the Dordogne, at the top of the hillsides.

b) – Description of the human factors contributing to the link

The cultivation of the vine is introduced under the Roman occupation. Later, convinced of the strategic military position of the Tertre de Fronsac, Charlemagne builds there one of the most powerful fortresses of the region, Franciacus, the camp of the Franks, on ancient Gallo-Roman fortifications, at the origin of the name of the region.

In the 18th century, Louis-François Armand du Plessis, nicknamed “Fronsac”, great-great-nephew of Cardinal de Richelieu and of the Marshal Duke of Richelieu, inherits the duchy of Fronsac and advocates the use of these wines at the court of Versailles. He erects at the summit of the Tertre de Fronsac a folly that can still be admired.

During the second half of the 18th century, neighbouring Libourne notables settle on the hillsides dominating the Dordogne, perfect the wine-growing activity and produce recognised wines, making these hillsides, according to professor Henri Enjalbert: “the historic cradle of the great wines of the Libourne area” (Enjalbert, H. - Les Grands Vins de Saint-Emilion, Pomerol et Fronsac - 1983). Like all the wines of the Libourne area, the port of Libourne and its trading activity actively participate at that time and throughout the 19th century in the trade and the diffusion of the wines of “Fronsac”.

The red wines of this region, initially recognised under the controlled designation of origin “Côtes de Fronsac” by decree of 4 March 1937, are, at the request of the wine-growers' union, recognised under the controlled designation of origin “Fronsac” by decree of 21 September 1976.

For several decades, the agricultural space of the commune has been largely devoted to the cultivation of the vine. Production there remains family-run, the holdings having an average area of about 6 hectares. The vineyard of the controlled designation of origin “Fronsac” covers, in 2009, 818 hectares for an average annual production of 40,000 hectolitres.

2° – Information on the quality and characteristics of the product

This vineyard produces still red wines with the merlot N variety, well suited to the clay-limestone hillsides where it reaches a great ripeness, and often accompanied by the cabernet franc N and cabernet-sauvignon N varieties which bring freshness and structure, which increases the ageing potential of these wines and their aromatic complexity. The malbec variety is the fourth variety planted after merlot, cabernet franc and cabernet-sauvignon. It also expresses itself very well on limestone, clay-gravelly or clay-limestone soils. Blended with merlot and the cabernets, it gives the wine more tannic amplitude, with aromas of small black fruits and liquorice. The wines are of an intense colour, tinged with purple or ruby. They present a powerful nose, with aromas of red fruits, with notes often truffled, sometimes gamey or mineral according to the nature of the soil. Their texture combines both robustness and elegance, a guarantee of an excellent aptitude for ageing. Carmenère N and petit verdot N (within the limit of 10 % each), old Bordeaux varieties, may complete the grape varieties.

3° – Causal interactions

"Fronsac" is a wine-growing territory recognised for its qualities for several centuries. Situated at the confluence of two rivers, the Dordogne and the Isle, water is omnipresent there. This presence of water contributes to creating a mesoclimate that reduces the risk of night-time frosts in spring, while attenuating the heat in the summer period.

Reflecting the usages, the delimited parcel area classifies the parcels situated either on the limestone plateaux whose permeability ensures a good drainage, or on the molassic slopes whose incline facilitates the flow of the waters. Excluded are the parcels on modern alluvium (palus) on the river bank.

In order to preserve the characteristics of the soils that constitute a fundamental element, any substantial modification of the morphology of the relief and of the natural pedological sequence of the parcels intended for the production of the controlled designation of origin is prohibited, as is the addition of exogenous soil onto parcels classified within the delimited parcel area. In addition, the grassing of the "headlands", a vegetated strip around the parcel, is compulsory in order to limit erosion and runoff, which are significant in the hillside zones. These delimited parcels allow the optimal expressions of the local varieties, selected over the course of history and in particular of the merlot N variety, particularly well suited to the clay-limestone hillsides. These varieties, cultivated under an oceanic climate, required, from the 17th and 18th centuries, supporting stakes, then the generalisation of trellising and a rigorous pruning method to ensure a good distribution of the harvest and a leaf surface sufficient for photosynthesis for an optimal ripeness. In order to ensure a sufficient harvest, without overloading the vine plants, a guarantee of ripeness and optimal concentration of the fruit, the minimum planting density is high.

Combining the mastery of production, the optimal conditions of ripeness and the historic requirements of aptitude for long-distance transport, the wines possess a structure allowing them a good conservation and thus present an excellent aptitude for ageing. The ageing, at least until 1 June of the year following that of the harvest, allows them to improve, ensuring their stabilisation, the combination of the tannins with the anthocyanins, which brings more roundness and a better expression before being placed on the market for the consumer.

This region, set within the Libourne landscapes, acquired its renown over the course of history despite difficult wine-growing crises. By preserving a rigorous delimitation of the parcels and practices stemming from the ancient usages, the producers preserve the originality and the renown of the controlled designation of origin "Fronsac", among the great wines of Bordeaux.

XI. – Transitional measures

1° – Training methods:

Parcels of vines in place at the date of 31 July 2009 and presenting a planting density between 4,500 plants per hectare and 5,000 plants per hectare and a spacing between rows less than or equal to 2 metres continue to benefit, for their harvest, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until their grubbing-up and until the 2040 harvest included, subject to compliance with the trellising and foliage-height rules laid down in the present specification.

XII. – Rules of presentation and labelling

1° – General provisions

Wines for which, under the terms of the present specification, the controlled designation of origin “Fronsac” is claimed and which are presented under the said appellation may not be declared after the harvest, offered to the public, dispatched, put up for sale or sold unless, in the harvest declaration, in advertisements, on leaflets, labels, invoices and any containers whatsoever, the aforesaid controlled designation of origin is entered.

2° – Particular provisions

The labelling of the wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin may specify the larger geographical unit “Vin de Bordeaux” or “Grand Vin de Bordeaux”. The dimensions of the characters of the larger geographical unit are not greater, both in height and in width, than two thirds of those of the characters composing the name of the controlled designation of origin.

CHAPTER II

I. – Declaration obligations

1. Claim declaration

The claim declaration is sent to the defence and management body before 15 February of the year following that of the harvest.

It indicates:

- the designation claimed;

- the volume of the wine;

- the EVV or SIRET number;

- the name and address of the applicant;

- the place of storage of the wine.

It is accompanied by:

- a copy of the harvest declaration, accompanied by the SV11 for the cooperative cellars and, as the case may be, a copy of the production declaration or an extract of the stock accounts for buyers of grapes and musts;

- the cellar plan (place of vinification and storage), allowing in particular the number, designation and capacity of the containers to be identified, if it has been modified since the last plan transmitted.

2. Prior declaration of removals or packaging

Every operator wishing to move or package wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin declares, to the approved control body, any bulk removal or packaging operation at least five working days before the operation.

Any operator who packages at least once a week for more than nine consecutive months in the year is considered a continuous packager. This operator is exempt from the prior declaration for each operation but must send half-yearly a copy of the handling register to the approved control body.

Any operator who packages at least once a week for more than three months in the year and less than nine successive months in the year is considered a semi-continuous packager. This operator is exempt from the prior declaration for each operation but must declare the packaging period(s) and send a copy of the handling register at the end of the indicated period to the approved control body.

Any operator who does not belong to one of the two other categories is considered a discontinuous packager. This operator must make a prior packaging declaration five working days before each operation.

3. Declaration relating to the dispatch outside the national territory of a non-packaged wine

Every operator wishing to carry out a dispatch outside the national territory of a non-packaged wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin makes the declaration thereof to the approved control body at least fifteen working days before the dispatch.

4. Fallback (repli) declaration

Every operator marketing a wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin under a more general appellation makes the declaration thereof to the defence and management body and to the approved control body within a maximum period of one month after this fallback.

5. Downgrading declaration:

Every operator carrying out a downgrading of wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin makes the declaration thereof to the defence and management body and to the approved control body within a maximum period of one month after this downgrading.

6. Reworking of parcels:

Before any addition of soil or amendment, any development or any works liable to modify the soil profile or the morphology of the relief, and with the exception of classic deep-ploughing works, a declaration is sent by the operator to the defence and management body at least two months before the start of the envisaged works. The defence and management body transmits, within eight days, the copy of the declaration to the services of the National Institute of Origin and Quality.

II. – Keeping of registers

1. Vines under derogatory measures

Every operator concerned by the transitional provisions set at point XI of Chapter I must keep available for the officers in charge of the control the inventory of the parcels concerned and the modifications made to these parcels, in particular a copy of the declaration of completion of works, in the event of grubbing-up and replanting.

2. Tasting register

All the packaged lots must be the subject of an organoleptic examination before and after packaging in accordance with the arrangements provided for in the inspection plan, an examination whose results are recorded in a tasting register.

CHAPTER III

I – Main points to be checked and evaluation methods

MAIN POINTS TO BE CHECKED	EVALUATION METHODS
A – STRUCTURAL RULES	
A1 – Belonging of the planted parcels to the delimited area	Documentary check (using a Geographic Information System and the up-to-date CVI record) and in the field
A2 – Claimable production potential (grape varieties and proportion rules, monitoring of transitional measures, planting density and trellising, abandoned vines)	Checks carried out: documentary (based on the CVI grape-variety record and the Geographic Information System data); in the field
A3 – Processing, ageing, packaging and storage facilities	
Place of vinification	Documentary check and on-site check
Minimum vinification capacity	Documentary check (inventory of containers)
Traceability of packaging	Documentary check (register keeping) and on-site check
Justified and protected storage place for packaged products	Documentary check and on-site check
B – RULES LINKED TO THE PRODUCTION CYCLE	

B1 – Management of the vineyard. — Pruning	Counting of the number of free eyes (buds) per stock and description of the pruning method
Trellising rules and foliage height	Check in the field
Average maximum load per parcel	Check in the field in the six weeks preceding the harvest. Counting of bunches per linear metre and estimation of the load
Cultivation condition of the vine	Check at the parcel. Criteria for analysis of the state of the vines: significant presence, in the parcel, of woody plants other than the vine; significant presence of cryptogamic diseases.
B2 – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes. — Ripeness of the grapes	- Verification of the records (information sheet specifying the maturity-monitoring method and the fermentable-sugar contents) at the operators'; - by visual examination of the grapes
B3 – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage. — Oenological practices or treatments (enrichment)	Documentary check and on-site check
B4 – Harvest declaration and claim declaration. — Missing vines	Documentary check (up-to-date list) and check in the field
Authorised yield	Documentary check [check of declarations, yield increase for certain operators (monitoring of the authorisations granted by the INAO services, after enquiry by the said services upon individual request of the operator)]
VSI, volumes harvested in excess of the authorised yield.	Documentary check (monitoring of destruction certificates)
Claim declaration	Documentary check and on-site check (compliance with the arrangements and deadlines, consistency with the harvest declaration, production declaration…). Control of the placing into circulation of the products
C – CHECKS ON THE PRODUCTS	
Non-packaged wines, at removal	Analytical and organoleptic examination
Packaged wines	Analytical and organoleptic examination
Non-packaged wines intended for a dispatch outside the national territory	Analytical and organoleptic examination of all the lots

II. – References concerning the control structure

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The control of compliance with the present specification is carried out on the basis of an approved control plan and by a third-party body offering the guarantees of competence, impartiality and independence and having received delegation from the INAO.
